



Sweden



The largest Scandinavian country by both population and area, Sweden has one of the world's most extensive welfare systems and is among the leading proponents of equal rights for women.



GEOGRAPHY

Heavily forested, with many lakes. Northern plateau extends beyond the Arctic Circle. Southern lowlands are widely cultivated.



CLIMATE

Southern coasts warmed by Gulf Stream. Northern areas have more extreme continental climate.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The nuclear family forms the basis of society, but the marriage rate is one of the lowest in the world, and cohabitation is now common. The model welfare system is paid for by a high tax burden. Women are well represented at all levels. A minority of 20,000 Sámi lives in the far north. Most industries and the bulk of population are based in and around the southern cities. An EU member since 1995, Sweden has voted not to join the euro.



THE ECONOMY

Companies of global importance, including Volvo, Saab, SKF, Ericsson. Highly developed infrastructure. Up-to-date technology. Skilled workforce.



INSIGHT: Sweden has maintained a position of armed neutrality since 1815



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Sweden

DATE OF FORMATION: 1523

CAPITAL: Stockholm

POPULATION: 9.25 million

TOTAL AREA: 173,731 sq. miles
(449,964 sq. km)

DENSITY: 58 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Swedish*, Finnish, Sámi

RELIGIONS: Evangelical Lutheran 82%, other 13%, Roman Catholic 2%, Muslim 2%, Orthodox Christian 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Swedish 86%, recent immigrant 12%, Finnish and Sámi 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Swedish krona = 100 öre